ABITUR ENGLISH · LANGUAGE

Commas

Where English and German punctuation differ

THE BASIC DIFFERENCE

German: a comma before every subordinate clause – **grammar** decides.

English: commas mark **introductions, extra information and pauses** – **meaning** decides.

That is why German speakers often put commas where English has **none** (N1–N7) and forget them where English **needs** one (C1–C10). In corrections, comma mistakes are marked **p** (punctuation).

No comma in English (but often in German)

RULE	WRONG	RIGHT
N1 **No comma before *that*** DE: „…, dass“	× The author claims**,** that young people are moving back.	✓ The author claims that young people are moving back.
N2 **No commas around defining relative clauses** The clause tells you **which** people/things are meant – you cannot leave it out.	× People**,** who live in cities**,** pay high rents.	✓ People who live in cities pay high rents.
N3 **No comma before indirect questions** *what, why, how, whether, if*	× It is unclear**,** whether the camps really help.	✓ It is unclear whether the camps really help.
N4 **No comma before a *to*-infinitive** DE: „…, um zu …“	× Many parents decide**,** to send their children away.	✓ Many parents decide to send their children away.
N5 **No comma when the subordinate clause comes after the main clause** *because, if, when, before, after, until, as soon as*	× Teenagers book places**,** because they want a break.	✓ Teenagers book places because they want a break.
N6 **No comma between subject and verb** even when the subject is a whole clause	× What the author criticises**,** is the lack of buses.	✓ What the author criticises is the lack of buses.
N7 **No comma before *than* / *as* in comparisons**	× Living in Millbrook is cheaper**,** than living in a city.	✓ Living in Millbrook is cheaper than living in a city.

QUICK TEST FOR RELATIVE CLAUSES (N2 OR C3?)

Leave the clause out. **Is it still clear who or what is meant?**

- **Yes** → extra information → **commas** (C3). *My brother, who lives in Leeds, is a nurse.* (I have one brother.)
- **No** → necessary information → **no commas** (N2). *Students who read a lot write better.* (only those students)
- *that* is only used **without** commas. After a comma: *who* or *which*.

Signal words

COMMA AFTER THESE AT THE START	NO COMMA BEFORE THESE
However, Therefore, Furthermore, Moreover, In addition, Nevertheless, Consequently, As a result,	*that* (N1) · *to* + infinitive (N4) · *than / as* (N7)
First of all, Finally, For example, On the one hand, On the other hand, In conclusion, To sum up,	*what, why, how, whether, if* in indirect questions (N3)
According to the author, In the article, In my opinion,	*because, if, when, before, after, until* – when they follow the main clause (N5)

Comma in English

RULE	WRONG	RIGHT
C1 Comma after introductory words and phrases linking words always; short time/place phrases optional	× However the camps are expensive. / In the article the author …	✓ However**,** the camps are expensive. / In the article**,** the author …
C2 Comma when the subordinate clause comes first like German	× When they return home old habits come back.	✓ When they return home**,** old habits come back.
C3 Commas around non-defining relative clauses extra information – you could put it in brackets; also *which* referring to a whole clause	× Ben Huang who works for a Seattle company moved back.	✓ Ben Huang**,** who works for a Seattle company**,** moved back.
C4 Commas around extra information about a noun apposition	× Rachel Hughes a journalist from Bristol argues …	✓ Rachel Hughes**,** a journalist from Bristol**,** argues …
C5 Commas around linking words in the middle of a sentence *however, therefore, for example, of course*	× Critics however remain sceptical.	✓ Critics**,** however**,** remain sceptical.
C6 Comma after an opening participle clause	× Having read the letter she decides to stay.	✓ Having read the letter**,** she decides to stay.
C7 Comma between two main clauses joined by *but, so, or* before *and* only if the clauses are long	× The town is small but it has fast internet.	✓ The town is small**,** but it has fast internet.
C8 Commas in lists the comma before *and* (Oxford comma) is optional – be consistent	× parents teachers and psychologists	✓ parents**,** teachers(**,**) and psychologists
C9 Comma to introduce or end direct speech	× She says “I wanted her to remember.”	✓ She says**,** “I wanted her to remember.”
C10 Numbers: comma for thousands, point for decimals DE: 1.500 · 2,5 %	× 1.500 people · 2,5 percent	✓ 1**,**500 people · 2**.**5 percent

NEVER: THE COMMA SPLICE

Two main clauses must **not** be joined by a comma alone – not even with *however* or *therefore*.

× *The town is small, it has fast internet.*

× *The camps are popular, however, they are expensive.*

✓ *The town is small. It has fast internet.*

✓ *The town is small, but it has fast internet.*

✓ *The camps are popular; however, they are expensive.*

Model paragraph

ALL RULES MARKED

In her article,C1 Rachel Hughes,C4 a journalist,C4 argues thatø N1 digital detox camps are becoming more and more popular. According to the author,C1 many parents whoø N2 worry about their children's well-being book a place. Teenagers,C5 however,C5 also sign up themselves becauseø N5 they want a break from being available all the time. When they return home,C2 old habits often come back,C3 which is why critics doubt thatø N1 the camps have a lasting effect. Moreover,C1 a stay can cost £1,500C10 or more,C7 so only wealthy families can afford it.

Blue = comma, with its rule. Grey ø = German would have a comma here, English has none.

ALSO REMEMBER

- Dates and places at the start: On 3 March 2026**,** the article … · In Wales**,** …
- *Yes / No* and addressing someone: Yes**,** I agree. · Thank you**,** Sarah.
- Question tags: It's expensive**,** isn't it?
- Letters and e-mails: Dear Mr Smith**,** … Yours sincerely**,** / Best wishes**,**
- Contrast with *although, whereas, while* after the main clause: a comma is common – Rents are high**,** whereas houses are cheap.

Practice: comma or no comma?

1. The author claims that young people are moving back to small towns.
2. In the article the author describes three reasons.
3. Ben Huang who works for a company in Seattle has moved to Millbrook.
4. People who live in cities pay much higher rents.
5. When the teenagers come back old habits return.
6. The camps are popular however they are very expensive.
7. Many parents book a camp because they are worried about their children.
8. The town has 12500 inhabitants.
9. The mayor is optimistic but critics are less sure.
10. What the author criticises is the lack of public transport.

Key: 1 no comma (N1) · 2 In the article, (C1) · 3 Ben Huang, who … Seattle, has (C3) · 4 no comma (N2) · 5 come back, old (C2) · 6 popular; however, they / popular. However, they (comma splice) · 7 no comma (N5) · 8 12,500 (C10) · 9 optimistic, but (C7) · 10 no comma (N6)